

Countability

A Quick-Reference Guide

Brief Blurp:

Countability is sometimes reduced to a single point. However:

A) That distinction has no clear and practical definition.

B) There are many types of "exceptions."

To replace the impractical single "rule," below are eight categories of situations for countability:

#	Pattern Description	Sample Words	Example Sentences
1	<u>The Simple Version:</u> There are 2 forms: 1. Things you can count vs. 2. Stuff you can't count.	Countable: - clock - window - mouse Uncountable: - paint - air -heat - ice cream	Would you like two clocks? Give me three clocks. Would you like some paint? I asked for one bucket of paint, but all I got was some air in one container.
2	<u>"(Un)countable" for no reason:</u> e.g. Items that can be counted but which are nevertheless "uncountable" like pieces of paper (vs. sand grains that are usually microscopically small and justifiably uncountable).	Paper (uncountable) Sea (countable)	I have two cards, and two pieces of paper, but I can't tell which are which. This is a sea, but it has no clear boundaries. There are two seas; they look like one blob.
3	<u>Exceptional Situations, Events:</u> Specific Contexts and Situations with common "Exceptions"	Beverages, in a restaurant.	<u>Restaurant or dining only:</u> "Give us two coffees, one water, four sodas, and one tea, please."
4	<u>Synonyms (same meaning) that are not both (un)countable:</u>	money vs. dollars; bag vs. luggage; paper vs. card; sea vs. water;	
5	<u>One word with two mostly-different meanings, where one can be countable:</u>	toast paper glass	<u>Toast 1:</u> Bread, uncountable. Please have some toast. He ate a piece of toast. <u>Toast 2:</u> Drinking: Kampai! Countable He made two toasts to a successful year in business.
6	<u>One word, mostly-the-same meaning, different forms of the word, where one can be countable:</u>	- Light, Helping - time vs. times vs. timing - Grass (species), - gas (science), - cake and pie,	"Helping": He needs some help/(some helping out). She needs two helpings* of ice cream. *"helpings" = "servings" ("help yourself" = "serve yourself") a serving of food: 内容量 ないより よう...etc. two helpings means two servings
7	<u>One word used both ways:</u> (in any context)	forest, report, egg, noise, sound, problems, light, watermelon	I heard two noises. I heard some noise from over there. I ate two watermelons. I ate some watermelon.
8	<u>Strangely Plural Items:</u> expecially where there is no "singular" but only a plural "...a pair of fish..."	e.g. "pants" and "glasses" may not be "countable" in "single" form. varies kinds of eye and leg/waist items are oddly uncountable and have no normal "singular form": goggles, glasses, trousers, panties, pants, binoculars, Also: sissors/...maybe sheers, clippers, (others do there is such a thing as one "contact lens")	
9	Counts in terms of a set: a set # (most)	(countable in #-units) pairs (anything: Scissors, sheers, clothes, glasses); decks (52 cards); dozens (12 anything); gaggles (is quasi numbered >5) (note: flock, herd, chord (wood), school (fish) vaguely mean "group") see "terms of ventry"	